

Plan Your Own Evaluation

Module 2 · Day 4, Session 3: Building on Module 1

3ie

0 • The last session

Four days. One design.

On Monday you learned what a comparison is. Tuesday, three more ways of building one. Wednesday, what a result costs and what a figure hides. Thursday, how to tell whether evidence is credible and how to translate it.

Today you apply it to your own evaluation. By the end: one completed template per team and a five-minute pitch. Part 1, 20 minutes; Part 2, 30 minutes; pitches from about 85 minutes in.

Pick one member's Module 1 design, the most developed one.

How far along is your design? Not started / rough outline / drafted / ready to pitch.

1 · Where your design stands

The eight conditions, from Module 1

The eight conditions for a credible impact evaluation

#	Condition
1	Intervention
2	Outcomes
3	Problem diagnosis
4	Theory of change
5	Dose and duration
6	Counterfactual
7	Data quality
8	Data sufficiency

These are Module 1's eight conditions. Part 1 of the template asks you to write your design against these, so the new work has something to attach to.

The one condition that decides the rest

Of the eight, which one matters most for a credible estimate?

The counterfactual.

Every method this week has been a different way of operationalising it: randomisation, a cut-off, a matched comparison, a parallel trend.

Each one has its own way of failing. If you cannot state yours in one sentence, the design is not finished.

What is your counterfactual, in one sentence? Write it now; you will read it out in the pitch.

Working time

Twenty minutes. Part 1 of the template: write your design as it stands, against the eight conditions.

Roles: scribe, timekeeper, presenter.

Which member's Module 1 design is most developed? Work from it. With no document to hand, the recap in each template row is enough: write what you would do.

Do not polish. This is the foundation for Part 2, and Part 2 is what the pitch focuses on.

2 · The four additions

What you are adding

The four additions, and where each came from

Addition	From
Results presentation plan	Day 2 and Day 4 Session 1
Cost-benefit framework	Day 3 Session 1
Data visualisation sketch	Day 3 Session 2
Evidence translation plan	Day 4 Session 2

Each addition applies one session from this week to your design.

Which of the four is hardest to do **before** you have any data? Why?

Addition 1: results presentation plan

What will you show, to whom, and in what order? Name the one number you will lead with, and say what the reader must **not** be able to conclude from it.

This morning's lesson, applied

The fictitious report led with its largest estimate and called a different one its preferred specification. A reader who stopped after the summary would have believed the threshold was met, when the preferred estimate did not meet it.

So ask: "What will a reader who reads only the headline come away believing, and is that true?"

Addition 2: cost-benefit framework

What are your **decision rule**, **benefit per unit per year**, **horizon** and **discount rate**? State which of those choices decides the answer.

Wednesday's lesson

In the GreenWaste example the horizon moved the ratio more than the discount rate did, and reports often leave the horizon unstated.

Write your horizon down. In GreenWaste, cutting the horizon from five years to two moved the ratio from 1.87 to 0.80.

Addition 3: data visualisation sketch

What figure carries your headline result? Sketch it, then sketch the **same data presented a second way**. What does the second version hide?

Wednesday's lesson

Each pair of figures showed identical numbers and different impressions: the truncated axis, the bar of means, the denominator, levels versus changes, discounting.

The second sketch matters more. If you cannot say what your preferred figure hides, expect it to come up in questions.

Addition 4: evidence translation plan

What is the **headline sentence** of your brief, with the number in it? What is the one thing your evaluation did **not** establish, stated plainly?

This morning's lesson

A brief that reports the estimate and omits the threshold leaves the reader to assume the target was met.

The second half is harder. Naming your own limit makes the pitch more credible.

Working time

Thirty minutes. Part 2 of the template: all four additions.

Work as a team. Draft all four; develop two in depth.

Which two additions will your team develop in depth?

Checkpoint at 15 minutes: each team reads out its counterfactual sentence.

Stress-test your design with AI

Type your Part 1 answers and your counterfactual sentence into the AI tool. Prompt:

"You are a sceptical commissioner. Ask me three questions about this design before you comment. Then name the one assumption that, if it broke, would make the estimate wrong."

Check its answer in a fresh chat.

Five-minute break

Back in five minutes. When we return: the pitches.

3 · The pitch

Five minutes, five parts

The pitch structure

Part	Time	What it says
The question	0:45	The decision this evaluation informs, and the counterfactual you will use.
The design	0:45	Why that design identifies the effect, in two sentences and no jargon.
The four additions	2:00	One minute on presentation and costing, one on the figure and the translation.
The main limit	0:45	What your design cannot establish, said before the ask.
What you want	0:45	The specific decision or resource you are asking for.

Note the order. **The limit comes before the ask.**

Why the limit comes before the ask

If you tell the room what your design cannot do, why would that make them more likely to give you what you want?

Because it tells them **which parts you have already thought about**. A pitch with no stated limits leaves the room to guess them.

It also changes what you are asking for. If you know your design cannot establish X, you can ask for what would, which is a more specific request than “fund the evaluation”.

Feedback from the room

Three minutes per team. The room gives feedback in this order:

1. **What is the design?** Say it back in one sentence. If you cannot, that is the feedback.
2. **What would make it fail?** The one assumption that would have to break.
3. **What is missing?** One thing you would have wanted to hear.
4. **Which trap from this week could hit it?** Headline vs preferred estimate, horizon, truncated axis, missing threshold.

Write it down, so the team can use it. Aim it at the design, never at the team.

4 • The week in one slide

What you can now do

1. Say what a number is compared to, and why that comparison matters.
2. Read DiD, RDD and matching results, and name the assumption each rests on.
3. Judge whether a benefit-cost ratio clears a threshold, and what decides it.
4. See the same data drawn two ways, and say what each version hides.
5. Interrogate an evaluation with a checklist, and rate a report section by section.
6. Write a brief a decision-maker can act on without being misled.

Which of the six would you have said you could do on Monday morning? Which would you now add?

The one question

The question behind every session this week:

What is being compared to what, and why should those two things be comparable?

Which programme in your unit could you ask this about next week?

Thank you

The slides and handouts stay available on the course website.

What is the first evaluation decision you will make when you get back to your desk?